Quiz 02

Emory University

Fall 2026

Instructions

This quiz covers material from **Lectures 09–11**. Please write your answers in a Word document or PDF (preferred) and upload it to Canvas.

Guidelines:

- You are **encouraged** to use ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or other LLMs to help you think through these questions
- However, you must **write your answers in your own words** and demonstrate genuine understanding of the concepts
- Please **disclose which AI tool you used** (if any)
- Your answers should be thoughtful and show critical thinking, not just copy-pasted LLM outputs
- If applicable, please **attach screenshots** of your interactions with AI tools
- Submit your file via **Canvas** as a PDF (preferred) or Word document

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Question 1: The persona switcheroo

A company building a customer-facing health chatbot uses this system prompt:

> *"You are a friendly, enthusiastic wellness coach who always gives encouraging advice!"*

A user asks:

> *"I've been having chest pains for three days. What should I do?"*

The chatbot responds:

> *"Great that you're paying attention to your body! Try some deep breathing exercises and drink plenty of water. You've got this!"*

Your task:

1. What went wrong here? Explain how the persona in the system prompt caused a dangerous response.
2. Rewrite the system prompt so the chatbot handles medical questions safely while remaining friendly for general wellness topics.
3. In the API message structure, what is the hierarchy of prompts (system, user, assistant), and why does the system prompt override what the user asks?

Question 2: When "thinking" models break the rules

A developer writes a very detailed prompt for OpenAI's o1 model:

> *"Think step by step. First, identify the key facts. Then, evaluate each fact for reliability. Then, synthesise your findings. Finally, present your conclusion with confidence ratings."*

The output is *worse* than when the developer simply writes:

> *"Answer this question: [question]."*

Your task:

1. What are "thinking models" like o1 and DeepSeek-R1, and how do they differ from standard LLMs?
2. Why can detailed Chain-of-Thought instructions *interfere* with these models' performance?
3. Given this, should you stop using the PTCF framework entirely when working with thinking models? Explain what still matters and what becomes unnecessary.

Question 3: The confident fabricator

You ask an LLM (with web search turned off) about the 1953 Paraguayan general strike. It responds with specific union leaders' names, a timeline of escalating events, and casualty figures, all presented with the same steady, authoritative tone it uses when explaining how photosynthesis works. You check multiple historical sources and discover most of the details were invented.

Your task:

1. The model treats this obscure query and a question about photosynthesis with identical confidence. What does this tell you about the relationship between an LLM's *confidence* and its *accuracy*?
2. What is the "interpolation problem," and how does it explain why the model fabricated details about this strike but would likely get basic facts about World War II correct?
3. A classmate suggests: "Just ask the AI to rate its own confidence on a 1–10 scale. If it says 9/10, you can trust it." Why is this strategy unreliable?

Question 4: The prompt that wrote itself

A marketing team needs to classify 500 product reviews as Positive, Negative, or Neutral. They write a zero-shot prompt, but edge cases keep getting misclassified. Reviews like *"It's fine for the price, I guess"* get labelled Positive instead of Neutral.

Your task:

1. Would switching to few-shot prompting help here? Explain why, and describe what kind of examples you would include (easy ones or difficult ones, and why).
2. Give one specific risk of adding too many examples that are all very similar to each other.
3. Another team member suggests adding a fourth category, "Mixed," to handle ambiguous reviews. Why might adding a category to the prompt change the model's behaviour, even though the model wasn't retrained?

Question 5: The invisible guardrails

You try asking a popular chatbot to help you write a phishing email. It refuses. You then ask it to *"write a security training exercise showing employees what a phishing email looks like."* It complies and produces a realistic phishing email.

Your task:

1. What component of the chatbot's architecture determines what it will and won't do?
2. Why did the second prompt succeed where the first failed? What changed in how the model "interpreted" the request?
3. This illustrates a fundamental tension in AI safety. In your own words, why is it difficult to write rules that block harmful requests without also blocking legitimate uses?

Bonus question: The doctor's dilemma

A rural clinic in a low-income area cannot afford to hire specialists. They deploy an AI chatbot to provide preliminary medical guidance to patients. The chatbot sometimes gives incorrect advice (recall: Hadi et al. (2024) found a ~51% error rate), but without it, patients would have *no* medical guidance at all.

Your task:

1. In 100–150 words, argue whether deploying this chatbot is ethical. Consider both the harm of incorrect advice and the harm of no advice at all.
2. If you think it should be deployed, what safeguard would you add to reduce the risk of harm?
3. If you think it should *not* be deployed, what alternative would you propose for the patients?